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Saddam Enough



Once upon a time in Mesopotamia ruled the most dangerous man on earth, the beast of mass destruction, and the singular threat to humanity. He was the last tyrant of Arabia, the B'athist Caligula who abhorred questions in his Kingdom of Fear. He had to go. For the sake of civilisational well being. So, in a daring act of international idealism, the guardian of the moral imperium went to war, and every missile that fell on Baghdad was legitimised by the imperatives of a just war. The liberation of Iraq had a fitting finalé when the bearded, dishevelled dictator emerged from a spider hole and declared, in a pathological mix of submission and delusion, "I am Saddam Hussein, the President of Iraq". Faraway in Washington, the other President—the liberator, the evangelist of democracy—smirked in triumph: ah well, you miss Osama, you get Saddam. After a prolonged show trial and the inevitable hanging which was more tribal than constitutional, Saddam joined the ghosts who swarm liberated Iraq today. The war is still on but morality is not what sustains it any longer. Maybe America needs a dictator as evil as Saddam in action to regain the moral momentum on the war on terror. There is one but the moral warrior in Washington has made no public pronouncement on General Pervez Musharraf's declaration of Emergency in Pakistan. George Bush wanted Iraq de-Saddamised. He got really angry when the Burmese junta silenced the barefoot monks of freedom. Why is it that the military dictatorship of Musharraf is not worthy of his moral attention, in spite of the Pakistani being Saddam enough?

The most obvious answer is: Musharraf is part of the Bush morality. In combating the larger evil of jihad, he needs the Pakistani dictator who has, after all, made the capture of quite a few high profile Al-Qaeda operatives possible. And that is why 9/11 has become such a fantastic business opportunity for Musharraf, who has reportedly received \$10 billion in aid from America since the Al-Qaeda attack. Today Pakistan may be the unofficial headquarters of radical Islamism and Musharraf one of its prized targets. Still, he is not some misplaced Ataturk. Jihad doesn't serve his purpose any longer—it is as simple as that. Musharraf has realised that it is not that easy for him to continue as America's general and Taliban's benefactor at the same time. Today his paranoia has reached the Saddam level and Washington's post-9/11 morality is turning out to be as dubious as Musharraf's invocation of Abraham Lincoln to postpone his mortality.



RANJAN RAHI



Protection Politics

PATNA The Nitish Kumar Government has withdrawn the Special Security Group (SSG) cover of Lalu Prasad Yadav. Under the SSG Act, the special security cover—entailing protection by 30 commandos—is available to a former chief minister for five years from the day he demits office. For Lalu, the period ended on September 25.

But the withdrawal of the cover will not render him security-less—he will remain in the Z-plus category. An elite cover of Railway Protection Force

also provides security to him, besides the NSG guards. The Z-plus security allows him a bullet-proof car, commandos, front and rear escorts, two policemen for periphery protection, security for house and office and an inspector to supervise security setup.

"Nitish Kumar is so scared about his security that he keeps mine-proof vehicles. But I am not bothered," says Lalu. Obviously, Bihar politicians know how to gain mileage out of every issue.

by Amitabh Srivastava

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



Singh

In the Net

PATNA Reporting about musclemen politicians in Bihar could be a dangerous proposition. Janata Dal (U) MLA Anant Singh and his henchmen assaulted three television journalists in the city

when they met him for his reactions on the reported killing of a woman, who had earlier alleged sexual exploitation by the don-turned-legislator. Singh was later arrested on Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's orders. Before his arrest, Singh appeared to be getting away with everything—public display of AK-series guns, violation of the Wildlife Protection Act and also alleged demands for extortion. But the irony is that the dead woman's body is still unidentified.

by Amitabh Srivastava